

Veneers and the smile that rots below

Dante's *Inferno* reflects the political and social challenges its author, Dante Alighieri, faced as a member of Florence's White Party, which ultimately led to his death warrant and exile. Though he remains an orthodox Catholic, the poem exposes the Catholic Church as a veneer over Italy's older pagan past. This is shown by diction that suggests the pagans' innocence even as it damns them, a narrative perspective that reveals how Dante the author built hell, and the symbolism of Limbo which honors the pagans while still shutting them out. The church that steamrolled over Italy's pagan history is the same church that exiled Dante from his home in Florence, so his criticism of Limbo is also a critique of the institution he was once a part of.

While in the first circle of hell, Dante includes the rhetoric "sinless", "lacked Baptism's grace", and "though spared the fire" when referring to the pagans in limbo, noting that they "were born to" a faith that is not under Christ. In this description, Dante contrasts the pagans' innocence with their damnation, underlining how he objects to his heroes being in hell. The distinction that the pagans were born into this faith is important, since they did not choose not to follow Christ; they did not know, so ending up in hell was completely out of their control. This principle reflects a Catholic belief, especially in the Church of Dante's time, that those who didn't know any better still don't deserve heaven. Dante's inclusion of these details is a calculated attempt to highlight this dilemma as a criticism of the faith. More evidence of this is shown in Virgil's rhetorical question to Dante, "you do not question what souls these are", where Dante is including Virgil's preemptive nudge at the souls in hell. This interaction suggests that Dante may already have that information: he knows which souls these are, since he created the hell they are voyaging through. This moment distinguishes Dante the author from Dante the protagonist, showing that through Dante the protagonist's journey through hell, Dante the author will

stylistically enact his agenda on his characters and force them to face the exact ethical dilemmas he asks himself about institutionalized Catholicism.

Dante's limbo mirrors real-world architecture, culture, and history that support the Christian cosmos' creation, but it too is cast aside into limbo. The supporting roots of this Christian cosmos are pagan, borrowed by tradition, existent by bloodline, and the old anchor for the hope that used to guide humanity, but now those roots are condemned as heretical. Italy's paganism is its history, and under the law of false idolatry, it was shunned. This fractured Italian identity and created a hybrid moral exceptionalist approach: the public Catholic. St Lucia, the heaven-sent figure who intervenes in Canto II, is from my ethnic homeland, Sicily. My family in Sicily claims they are "publicly catholic". However, I still remember the prayer my grandma gave me to 'rid of malochio' and mass at the Duomo in Syracuse, where the church is held up by columns from the ancient Greek temple of Athena. Limbo works the way the Duomo does, with a Christian structure resting on pagan columns. Sicilian, Roman, Florentine, and broader Italian culture repeatedly show iterations of this fracture, the catholic-pagan veneer: Dante, a Florentine, is led through hell by a Roman pagan. Lucia herself, who asked Beatrice to find Virgil, shows the theft in action, as she too takes Greco-Roman paganistic qualities from deities in the region. Her persona stole attributes from the Roman goddess Lucina, the goddess of light and childbirth.

The Italian Catholic identity condemns the pagans of times past to limbo. However, it steals their deities and holidays as non-heretical inspiration, all the while overshadowing the historical folklore and coining it heresy. The church that overwrote Italy's past is the same church that exiled Dante from his home. Dante's issue with the staunch condemnation of paganism, shown through contrasting diction and intentional detail, underlines the role the

Catholic Church played in steamrolling centuries of tradition with public norms, and highlights exactly why Dante opposed church interference in Florentine politics.

LAD NOTES:

No tortured wailing rose to greet us here
but sounds of sighing rose from every side,
sending a tremor through the timeless air,
a grief breathed out of untormented sadness,
the passive state of those who dwelled apart,
men, women, children—a dim and endless congress.
And the Master said to me: “You do not question
what souls these are that suffer here before you?
I wish you to know before you travel on
that these were sinless. And still their merits fail,
for they lacked Baptism’s grace, which is the door
of the true faith *you* were born to. Their birth fell
before the age of the Christian mysteries,
and so they did not worship God’s Trinity
in fullest duty. I am one of these.
For such defects are we lost, though spared the fire
and suffering Hell in one affliction only:
that without hope we live on in desire.”
I thought how many worthy souls there were
suspended in that Limbo, and a weight
closed on my heart for what the noblest suffer.

-- from pdf 1-Dante, page 1029 of John Ciciardi's translation of Dante's divine comedy

Paraphrase:

Dante is on the brink of hell accompanied by his hero, Virgil, conceptualizing hell while being within it. Dante passes the hopeless pagans within limbo, those who have never gotten a chance to love Christ and go to heaven, for their time was before him. Dante thought of those of the pagans that might have been worthy and good, noting that they too, are in hell.

Observe:

The rhetoric “sinless”, “baptism’s grace”, “you were born to”, and “spared the fire” is potentially significant

The capitalization of Virgil as “Master” is potentially significant—heresy? Because Him=God, not a false idol

The rhetorical question “you do not question what souls these are” is potentially significant

Contextualize:

The fact Dante had been exiled from his home of Florence for heresy is potentially significant
The fact that Dante was politically involved and conflicted with institutional Catholicism and the papacy is potentially significant.

Contextualize further with personal cultural knowledge about Greek history in Sicily, my family’s homeland.

Analyze:

The capitalization of Master referring to Virgil is significant because normally a capitalized noun would refer to Jesus (ex: I am His), showing that Dante has established Virgil as a false idol which highlights his heresy and anger with the Catholic institution. (even if this is just done by the translator, it still proves true to the text so the stylistic change just underscores how Dante idolizes Virgil)

Virgil’s rhetorical question “you do not question what souls these are” is significant because Dante the author’s inclusion of this preemptive nudge is evidence of Dante the author’s opinion protesting this Catholic principal, that those born before Christ do not deserve everlasting life, representing more of his deviation from the church.

Dante the author’s loss to the Black party and exile from Florence is significant because it represents how the church has betrayed him personally, and he will go as far as heresy to get revenge. Dante’s heresy in making these writing choices represents his external conflict with the Catholic institution, his internal conflict with his faith, and his desire for a revenge that is just, but suitable (contrapasso?) for the crime committed against himself. These conflicts also mirror the conflict between Greco-Roman pagan history in Italy, and the Catholic church that has overwritten it.

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There is a power struggle between Dante the protagonist in hell and Dante the creator of hell, as well as a power struggle between catholicism and mysticism which together mirror the conflict Dante has battled within Italian politics, and the greater tension between the Italian public and catholic conservatism.

Before Italy was Italy, it was Roman, and before Sicily was Italy it was Roman, and before that, Sicily was Greek. Therefore it is fair to say that the “pagans” referenced in Dante’s *Inferno* were a major part of Italian history. So what happened? I believe Italian paganistic folklore, a vital identity that developed over centuries, was overshadowed by the Roman-Catholic church. It is clear that the Italian identity is strong, as evidenced by the strong overseas ties in long lasting ethnic enclaves in the northeastern United States, and the local regional identities each Italian defines themselves by. This strong identity faces a powerful catholic-conservative force in Italy: the struggle between the two is so significant that it has been present since the formation of the church and is still present today. St. Lucia, shown in Dante’s *Inferno* when the patron of the light sends a message from Beatrice to Virgil, is a true catholic saint whose qualities can be mapped back to greco-roman influence. St Lucia was born in Syracuse, Sicily, and her persona stole attributes from two major pagan entities that originally ruled over the light in the region. The Roman Lucina, goddess of light and labor, and the Greek Artemis, the goddess of the moon; whose Artemision temple sits over the highest point in Syracuse, on the island of Ortigia.

Lots of authentic Italian history, folklore, and tradition has been overwritten by catholicism and there is a contradiction between tradition in conservative Italy, and catholic wallpaper. Italy has “public” catholicism with private superstition. There is a power struggle between faith and heresy, not only within Dante’s 12 circles of hell, but also within Dante’s life himself. Speculating, and incorrectly on the contents of heaven is by definition also heretical.

Argue:

Dante’s *Inferno* reflects a series of political and social challenges that its author, Dante Alighieri, faced within the White party of Florence, which ultimately led to his death warrant and exile. Dante’s portrayal of hell, containing his enemies, idols, and worldview represents not only a series of identity conflicts within his own mind, but a greater political and historical conflict across the Italian identity itself. Through the establishment of false idols, protesting core catholic principles, and wanting to limit the political involvement of the papacy, Dante, despite being an orthodox catholic, directly criticizes institutional catholicism and the rigidity of the faith itself showing his religious disillusionment.